



SUNDAY Insight

Animal Abandonment: It's just not OKAY



By **MALVIKA VAZALWAR**

“The greatness of a nation and its moral progress can be judged by the way its animals are treated.”

--Mahatma Gandhi

For a country that boasts of great culture, morals and values, we have a shockingly large number of companion animal abandonment. So the more I see the quote that I love so much (and I see it everywhere!), the more it angers me. As though our collective actions delight in mocking this brilliant psychological and spiritual research all packed in one sentence. As though quoting this gives us a great head start in speeches to convince others of our intention while we secretly agree that it belongs in words and books alone. If we truly topped education it would trickle down to the most vulnerable and even our animals would reflect our state of being. But mostly we understand and use words like character in the wrong context; perhaps when we refer women with agency over their mind and body who challenge hierarchy. When have you heard word ‘character’ (or ‘characterless’ for that matter) referring the way we treat our pets? One context we conveniently forget to link words like ‘values, culture, character, ethics’ is in our view and treatment of them. Can’t we connect the dots? We may have PhDs but behind closed doors we may be uncivilized enough to unleash our frustration on the puppy who won’t tell. No amount of qualification would cover up for the homework in potty training that we did not do. We may follow celebrities and leaders but when it comes to adopting Indies like them, we may project the self-esteem issues of our colonized mind on the breed of the dog and want a foreign breed only; the one who’s not even built for the city heat. We may be parents who sob-watch *Baghban*, but we may not apply the same logic to our pet who relies on us like any two year old toddler does. We may have money for surplus vacations and stifling tuitions but we act stingy when it comes to sourcing good food, prompt vet care and hire the right trainer for

the dog. Not understanding this adds up, this shows. And finally, when it comes to moving cities we put up posts like “We are relocating. If our pet doesn’t get re-homed we will be forced to leave him behind on the street. Don’t judge. Help.” Don’t judge. Help? Despite the changing cultural norms: When people realised how they healed with the simple love language of their pets and evolved in their therapeutic presence. When all the more people are planning and saving to fly their Indies abroad like they would their children. When an Indian student refused to return from war-struck Ukraine without his rescue pet. Do we still not understand they are family? Or we have small hearts and minds to house them in? Or our love never becomes our verb? Why does all the schooling, civil behaviour, money, will power, effort, disappear in the face of our own pets? Is it because most are bought and once the money exchange is done off somebody’s reproductive system, the breeder won’t care even if the animal lives another day. Once they fulfill the instant gratification, the basic emotional gaps and meet the adrenaline rush of an impulsive thrill, they become an emotional wellness subscription you can now cancel and abandon? Is it that the pet doesn’t have a discerning foster parent interviewing, briefing in, monitoring, guiding and being emotionally invested in their development and life experience? That the pet does not have someone to advocate for them should the adopter turn out to be disappointing? When we break these unspoken but obvious vows, what does this tell about us? What does it speak about our values, loyalty, and commitment, our Character - about the ones we accepted responsibility for and rely on us? Culture is a neutral entity, we feed it and make it alive and dynamic. And such immoral acts eat away at culture than any assumed ones. It’s not that neighbourhood girl wearing shorts or engaging in consensual sexual interaction, but that “respected and reputed” family abandoning their pet under some excuse, that’s detrimental. I find such threats of abandonment to be audaciously shameless and fearful of

judgment that only showcase ignorance, entitlement and poor lack of will and effort. It reveals a lack of accountability and civil behaviour and should not be accepted by our culture, since it’s certainly not accepted by our law. It’s so common to find re-adoption pleas on social media groups within few months of bringing the puppy home. On grounds like it turned out dog’s post fervently. After the dog who waits on the family to return and gets depressed when they don’t, the brunt is now paid by those who realise the fate of this dog. All rescuers and activists come like moths to a flame trying to pull up connections, luck and destiny to find this dog a home. So much high anxiety stress and burnout for a dog who should’ve never been in that place! In this culture of abandonment, the animals suffer and so do the other kind of humans who exemplify loyalty. They are not takers from the animals, they are givers. Sometimes, suffering from compassion fatigue, so one more animal can be rescued. All they want is time off for self-care and to live in a world where humans say and do the exact same thing, especially when they adopt from them. The same amount of time, intensity and effort of redoing and reinstating is a waste of human resource; compassion and will, just because we don’t have the necessary laws and implementation in place. Imagine, a community could scale efforts to sterilize dogs and secure a new life for a whole litter of homeless pups in place of constant revisions. (It’s more difficult to find a home for an adult. Although, giving a second chance to an adult or a senior has its own joy.) In my view, any person who starts this helter-skelter should be made to compensate for this. So I get a pinch of relief from fellow animal friends who demand this per-

son’s name, number & address in the comment section to file a police complaint, now that the evidence is here. Not all pets are this lucky. Many who get abandoned are invited to be as fun as the last one, they are then taken far from home so they won’t be able to use their highly functional sense of smell to sniff their way back. Many who do get rescued are reported to suffer from heartache, trauma, loss of stress and some even lose the will to live, stay stuck in a corner, head drooping, refusing to eat. Although there is scientific research that proves that dogs have feelings and abandonment affects them deeply, one doesn’t need research when one actually meets a dog who knows abandonment. One dog who was abandoned during lockdown is Roar. His first hour on this new street one morning, I remember seeing him waiting under a tree away from the other five community dogs whom I was feeding. He had a bad infection and a patch on his neck that said he wore a collar. Slowly, over the year, he integrated into the pack. He had developed resource guarding and insecurities that one can’t blame him for. Soon, he would follow me to the dog store nearby, chase the auto I was in, wait outside my home if I didn’t show up. Understandably, he was insecure about his source of food and care. Only recently, after returning from his neuter surgery has he found the trust and knows that he’s here to stay. Even now if he meets his favourite people after a long time of two days he is known to jump the wall to hug them and cry. Not every being thrives like Roar and they should not even find themselves lost, helpless and to the mercy of luck in the first place. And it is only up to us to create this cultural norm where once adopted the animal never knows homelessness ever again.

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“Even neglect that compromises with the animal’s emotional well-being, tethering that restricts the animal’s movement, not enjoying an identity and being excluded from the family are forms of abandonment to me. So far I’ve managed to rescue over 70 dogs who were stuck in such situations and agree that this only reflects the state of well being of the family. I have seized dogs from people we meet in our social circles and can’t imagine the harm they can cause to their own. We often rely on the help’s and neighbours’ vigilance,” revealed Animal welfare officer, Anjali Vaidyar, who’s been taking the legal route since eighteen years now. “Often evidence - a vehicle number or CCTV footage that helps identify, is not present. But don’t hold yourself back (although one can remain anonymous) people should feel there are vigilant people ready to hold them accountable,” she guided. **Steps:** 1. You can call 100/ police control room. Eg. You hear a dog constantly cry or tied up you can report it. 2. Additionally, you can file a complaint in the police station of the area of this crime. Most cops will cooperate. Insist if someone does not. (Share & Mention pictures in the complaint if you have them. Keep a copy. Follow up is key.) Neglecting an animal by denying her sufficient food, water, shelter and exercise or by keeping him chained/ confined for long hours is punishable by a fine or imprisonment of up to 3 months or both. Section 11(1) (h), PCA Act, 1960. **On the implementation of laws:** “In past, while an official letter throwing light on a pet parent’s bad behaviour reached his office department, I’ve never seen any imprisonment or fine being implemented. I believe the pet’s safety is priority so I try to curb my anger. In fact, I once had to mediate with a Judge who himself was going to abandon his dog. Now the dog is in my hostel care,” said Anjali. **End Note:** When I called 100, the in-charge at the control room sounded more equipped to guide me this time than my last call on 8th Jan about a neglected and permanently caged dog and another a month ago about one of my adopted puppies who was re-homed without my knowledge. Back then the person although well-intentioned could only suggest that I visit the local police station. This time I was guided that an injured or abandoned dog could be picked up and that an abused or neglected dog could be rescued. That he could send help to a given address. Since animal officers like Anjali are responsible for a large number of animals, we need to do our homework before taking their help so they can supervise better. Imagine one officer getting asked the steps over and over again by a dozen people a day. Just clarifying doubts can be time consuming. Most often people do nothing because the action is not broken down into small steps. We need clearer mass guidelines issued in public interest and a working helpline from our Municipal and law enforcement bodies so we can do our part without having to waste time in research from a scratch. It’s not enough to say or to know that abandonment is a crime.